

The 4-Step Task Triage System

Filter out administrative noise and protect your high-leverage work.

Most daily task lists fail because they are unstructured braindumps disguised as schedules. Without a rigorous filter, low-impact administrative tasks crowd out the deep work that actually moves your goals forward. Use this 4-step triage template every morning to ruthlessly separate real leverage from busywork.

Step 1: The Brain Dump & Capture

Before you can triage your workload, you need to get every pending commitment out of your head and into a single, centralized holding zone. Do not organize or evaluate these tasks yet; just capture them completely.

- List every request, lingering project, and open loop currently on your mind.
- Include incoming emails, Slack requests, and recurring maintenance duties.
- Stop once your working memory feels clear of pending obligations.

Step 2: The Value Filter (High-Leverage vs. Noise)

Evaluate every captured item against a strict value standard. Ask yourself: does this task directly generate primary outcomes, or does it merely maintain baseline operations? Be honest about what constitutes true leverage.

- High-Leverage: Directly drives primary metrics, creates strategic assets, or unblocks others.
- Administrative Noise: Routine formatting, low-context status updates, and disorganized digital upkeep.

Step 3: The 4D Action Assignment

Take every item that survived the value filter and assign it to one of four strict operational categories. This prevents tasks from sitting in a state of perpetual indecision.

- Do (High-Leverage): Execute these immediately during your peak cognitive hours.
- Delegate: Hand off administrative noise to someone else with clear context and a deadline.
- Defer: Schedule a specific future date and time for necessary medium-value tasks.
- Delete: Eliminate low-value tasks that generate zero measurable return.

Step 4: Time-Block & Boundary Setting

Once your daily 'Do' list is selected, map it directly onto your calendar in protected blocks. Never leave high-leverage work at the mercy of an open-ended to-do list.

- Assign fixed start and end times for your primary high-leverage block.
- Batch all remaining administrative tasks into a single, compressed afternoon window.
- Close communication channels during your primary high-leverage time block.

The Daily Triage Template

Copy and paste this clean text block into your daily planner or notes app to run the system in under five minutes every morning.

- [] 1. Capture: Write out all pending items.
- [] 2. Filter: Identify the top 20% that yield 80% of results.
- [] 3. Assign: Mark each item as Do, Delegate, Defer, or Delete.
- [] 4. Schedule: Time-block the 'Do' items and batch the admin work.

Run this 4-step checklist every morning before opening your email or chat apps to ensure you drive your day instead of reacting to it.